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LESS E-WASTE, MUCH WOW!

DR. APRAJITA SINGH OFFERS A CRITICAL PERSPECTIVE ON E-WASTE MANAGEMENT, EXPLORING ITS IMPLICATIONS FOR SUSTAINABILITY AND THE GROWING DEMAND FOR REFURBISHED GADGETS

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Q Can you elaborate on the current state of e-waste generation and management in India?

A E-waste generation and management in India is a critical issue, as India is the third-largest producer of e-waste globally, generating over 3.2 million metric tons annually. This volume is expected to increase due to the growing penetration of electronic devices and the shorter lifespan of gadgets.

Q India's biggest challenges in dealing with e-waste?

A Around 95% of e-waste in India is processed by the informal sector, where methods used are often rudimentary and hazardous, leading to environmental pollution and health risks. E-waste contains toxic substances like lead, mercury, and cadmium. Improper disposal and recycling practices lead to soil, water, and air pollution, affecting both ecosystems and human health. Although India has regulations in place, enforcement remains a challenge. Many producers and consumers

are either unaware or non-compliant with e-waste disposal laws.

Q What challenges do refurbished gadget resellers have in India?

A Established refurbished gadget resellers in India face several key challenges that can impact their growth and operations. Many consumers remain sceptical about the quality and longevity of refurbished gadgets. Despite efforts to ensure high standards, the perception that refurbished products are inferior to new ones can deter potential buyers. Maintaining a consistent and reliable supply of used gadgets for refurbishment can be difficult. The availability of high-quality, used devices suitable for refurbishment is often unpredictable, leading to challenges in meeting demand. Acquiring used gadgets at competitive prices is a significant challenge, especially when competing with other resellers and recyclers. Fluctuations in procurement costs can impact profitability. Navigating India's complex regulatory landscape, particularly in terms of e-waste management, import-export rules, and taxation, can be challenging. Compliance with varying regulations across states adds to the complexity.

Q Any advice on how we can all be more responsible tech consumers?

A Before purchasing a new gadget, ask yourself if you truly need it or if your current device can still meet your needs. Avoiding unnecessary upgrades reduces e-waste and conserves resources. When you do need a new device, consider buying refurbished gadgets. They are often just as reliable as new ones but come with a smaller environmental footprint.

When a device reaches the end of its life, don't just throw it away. Use authorised e-waste collection centres or recycling programs to ensure that your device is disposed of properly. Many companies offer trade-in programs where you can return your old devices for credit towards new ones. This ensures your old gadgets are either refurbished or recycled responsibly. Educate yourself about the environmental impact of electronic devices, from the extraction of raw materials to manufacturing, usage, and disposal. Being informed can help you make more sustainable choices. Share your knowledge about responsible gadget consumption with friends and family. The more people are informed, the greater the collective impact on reducing e-waste. **d**